

COLORADO RARE BIRD REPORT

RUBY-THROATED HUMMINGBIRD

Archilochus colubris

Red 2/2/01 upl

Location: Paulsen's yard, corner of SS and 7 road; north of Lamar, Prowers CountyDate: September 10, 2000

Brandon Percival and I were birding and visited the Paulsen's house on the afternoon of September 4th. It was a clear, sunny, still day. The Paulsen's yard is a farmhouse surrounded by plantings. The Paulsen's had put out a hummingbird feeder in a locust tree, near some trumpet vine. We had heard rumors that there was one or more hummingbirds in their yard and wanted to check it out. We almost immediately saw a hummer at the feeder. Over the next 45 minutes we observed two male hummers, both Ruby-throated. They were very faithful to perches (one in a juniper) and sat still for periods of time such that we were even able to get them in the scope. Otherwise we observed them with binoculars from between 20-50 feet distance. Up to four of this species were present in their yard at least through September 17th, with a female and immature male also around. I observed only an immature male with 3 small isolated red gorget feathers on September 17th. Scores of birders observed one or more of these Ruby-throateds at the Paulsen's in mid-September.

Description:

Two males:

Both birds were males in breeding plumage. They were quite silent, and their flight made a thin, faint whirring sound, unlike the shrill metallic sound of male Broad-tailed Hummingbirds. These were quite small Archilochus hummingbirds, about 3 1/2" long. They were comparable in size and build to Black-chinneds. The bill was medium-long and quite straight. The uppersides, crown and back of the bird were bright glossy green with a faint golden tone in some lights. The undersides were mainly white, with grayer flanks. The tail was remarkable, being dark (black or blackish) and deeply forked at rest. In flight, the tail feathers were completely black, lacking white tips. The gorget covered the chin, throat and lower sides to the face. The upper edge of the gorget below the eye was black, but the main part of the gorget was a bright, clear red. There was a tiny white spot behind and below the eye. In the shade the gorget could look blackish, but when the bird turned its head the red or slightly orangish-red gorget color became clear.

Immature male:

This bird as the adult male, but had white tipped tail feathers and only three small round feathers in the gorget with the red coloration. Otherwise the throat was dusky white and faintly lined.

Similar Species:

Selasphorus hummingbirds have rounded tails with white outer tail feathers. Calliope lacks solid-colored gorget. The others have orange-based tail feathers, unforked tails and possess more or less white on the face. Broad-tailed Hummingbird has a loud metallic whistle in flight. Black-chinned is most similar, but has a slightly longer bill, and a purplish-black, not red, gorget. I did not observe the in-flight tail-pumping that is more prevalent in Black-chinned.

Experience with Species:

I have seen all the Colorado hummingbirds, some many times, and have seen many Ruby-throated Hummingbirds in the east.

This report was prepared from notes made after observation.

Mark Janos
10 Sedum Ct.
Pueblo, CO 81001

